through, is now the last place I want to be. I'm starting to hate bowling. I hate even thinking about it.

It's a strange time to be developing a nervousness around cricket, because almost as if they are somehow linked, at the same time the rest of the country becomes wrapped up in it in the most vivid way in living memory. Australia come to England for the 2005 Ashes, and buoyed by what will ironically be the last summer of cricket on terrestrial television on Channel 4, there is a perfect combination of an England side stretching out and reaching beyond its recent history, against an Australian team undefeated in England for 26 years and still somewhere around their peak. I have not been bowling well for Lancashire and am not involved in the series to begin with. The Test series is on in the dressing room while I am resigned to County cricket, trying to find some more speed from somewhere, trying to juggle all the information I've been sent away to deal with and think on. As the series intensifies, I become like a fan, almost misremembering that there was ever a situation where I could have been involved in the games at all, or that it was even my dream. It all feels suddenly so far away. The four seamers England have are a perfect combination of different skills and attributes – Harmison with his speed and height, Hoggard with his hustle and ability to swing the ball, Jones with his effectiveness with reverse swing and Flintoff with his knack for bending important moments to his will. I watch on in awe from behind the sofa when England win by two runs at Edgbaston and, before I know it, I am getting hooked on it as if it's another world – one far away from mine. There's something quite surreal about it – watching the England team reach the public's imagination and cricket begin to fill the front pages of newspapers, the televisions of every pub, with games suddenly spilling out in parks and the common, while it becomes a Rubik's Cube to me, almost like a distant memory. I'm in such a strange run of it that when I'm selected for the squad for the last, decisive game at The Oval, I am relieved when they choose Paul Collingwood instead of me for the injured Simon Jones, shoring up the batting rather than going like for like. Where my game is at, I have a sense that I am not going to be able to contribute anything worthwhile and I will be overthinking it, and when the team celebrate on the roof of buses after the final day, winning the Ashes for the first time since 1986/87, a perfect summer of cricket wrapped up, it doesn't even